

Ἀέτιος ὁ Ἀμιδηνός

Aëtius of Amida and the Sixteen Books of Medicine

eul_aid: vhc

Period: Ὀψιμαρχαία [Late Antique](#)
Dialect: Κοινή τεχνική [Technical Koine](#)
Domain: Ἱατρική [Medicine](#)
Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)

Aëtius of Amida was a Byzantine physician and medical writer who lived and worked in the 6th century CE. He was born in the city of Amida in the eastern Roman Empire and served as a court physician to Emperor Justinian I in Constantinople. He was likely educated in the Alexandrian medical tradition, which focused on the teachings of earlier authorities like Hippocrates and Galen.

He is known for a single, massive work called the Libri Medicinales, sometimes referred to as the Tetrabiblos. This encyclopedia is organized into 16 books covering a wide range of medical topics, from general diseases and fevers to specialized areas like eye conditions, skin ailments, and gynecology. The work is not an original treatise but a detailed compilation of knowledge from many earlier Greek and Roman medical writers, and the full text survives.

Aëtius's primary historical importance lies in his role as a preserver of knowledge. His encyclopedia is considered one of the three major medical compilations from late antiquity. It is a crucial source for historians because it contains excerpts and ideas from many earlier physicians whose own works have been lost. His detailed sections on women's health were particularly influential for later medical traditions in the Byzantine, Arabic, and Renaissance worlds. His work exemplifies the late antique shift toward systematically organizing existing knowledge for practical use.

Works (14)

- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον Α' · [Medical Book I](#) · 372 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον Β' · [Medical Book II](#) · 270 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον Γ' · [Medical Book III](#) · 192 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον Δ' · [Medical Book IV](#) · 104 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον Θ' · [Medical Book IX](#) · 90 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον Ε' · [Medical Book V](#) · 159 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον Ζ' · [Medical Book VI](#) · 133 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον Ζ' · [Medical Book VII](#) · 146 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον Η' · [Medical Book VIII](#) · 121 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον ΙΑ' · [Medical Book XI](#) · 51 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον ΙΒ' · [Medical Book XII](#) · 96 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον ΙΓ' · [Medical Book XIII](#) · 31 passages
- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον ΙΕ' · [Medical Book XV](#) · 84 passages

- Ἱατρικὸν Βιβλίον ΙΖ' · Medical Book XVI · 179 passages